

matriedl@ceu-budapest.edu

Matthias Riedl, Central European University, Budapest

The Tree of Election: On the Symbolization of Spiritual Progress in Joachim of Fiore

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Introduction

One day, while he was dwelling on a mountaintop and meditating on the Book of Revelation, Joachim of Fiore (1135?-1202) suddenly had a vision of a tree. In his *Liber Concordiae*, he tells us that his vision by no means resembled a regular tree, as commonly found in mountain forests; rather it was the image of a tree given to him by the grace of God.¹ The vision stands in the long tradition of apocalyptic revelations and conforms to the original meaning of *apokalypsis*: an unveiling of God's plan for mankind, an insight into the structure of a divinely ordered history.² Consequently, the tree became a key symbol in Joachim's reflections about the progress of the people of God and the concordant course of Israel and the Church, the most prominent themes in his writings.

However, the symbol of the tree deviates from symbolic tradition in several respects. For one, it is tremendously more complex than classical apocalyptic symbols, such as the four empires in the Book of Daniel, the ten weeks in the apocryphal First Book of Enoch, or the seven seals in the Revelation of John. These symbols allow for a rough subdivision of history into four empires, ten ages, or seven persecutions; but a tree can have a large number of limbs, branches, and ever smaller divisions and, therefore, represent a much more complex image of the historical process. Even more important is the second deviation: the tree is an organic

¹ “ [...] talem nos cedri huius ymaginem assignare oportet, qualem eam pro dono gratie in montis uertice contemplati sumus, non quales in siluis montium consueuerunt inueniri. ” Joachim von Fiore, *Liber Concordiae Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, in ed. E. R. Daniel, *Transactions of the American Philosophical Society* 73/8 (Philadelphia, 1983), pp. 3-435, at p. 146. [Daniel's edition includes only books I-IV; sections from book V are cited from *Liber Concordiae Novi ac Veteris Testamenti* (Venice, 1519; reprint Frankfurt am Main: Minerva, 1964).]

² Revelation 1:1.

being, often growing a mighty crown out of a simple root. Some branches may die and fall off, while new ones emerge. Thus the tree allows for more than just symbolizing a sequence of times or ages; it allows for representing growth and progress, as a result of continuous cycles of decay and renewal. The tree proved to be a perfect symbol for expressing Joachim of Fiore's historical experience, resulting in a groundbreaking reconceptualization of the people of God and its course in history.

The tree as symbol

Long before Joachim acknowledged the value of the tree-image for understanding and calculating sacred history, the tree had almost universally served as one of the oldest and most widespread symbols in the history of religion. Already in prehistoric agricultural societies, Mircea Eliade claims, the sacred tree expressed two interrelated primordial experiences, the experience of life and the experience of the cosmos:

For the religious man, the appearance of life is the central mystery of the world. Life comes from somewhere that is not this world and finally departs from here and goes to the beyond, in some mysterious way continues in an unknown place accessible to the majority of the mortals. [...] All this, moreover, is ciphered in the cosmic rhythms; man need only decipher what the cosmos says in its many modes of being, and he will understand the mystery of life. But one thing seems clear beyond doubt: that the cosmos is a living organism, which renews itself periodically. The mystery of the inexhaustible appearance of life is bound up with the rhythmical renewal of the cosmos. This is why the cosmos was imagined in the form of a gigantic tree; the mode of being of the cosmos and first of all its capacity for endless regeneration, are symbolically expressed by the life of the tree.³

Such a sacred tree may be imagined as a cosmic pole, an axis mundi, marking the centre of the world and symbolizing its "rootedness" in an underworld as well as its connectedness to the cosmos at large and the dimensions of the transcendent and the divine.⁴ Thus the sacred

³ Mircea Eliade, *The Sacred and the Profane. The Nature of Religion* (San Diego: Harcourt Brace, 1959), pp. 147f.

⁴ *Ibid.* pp. 32-38.

tree interrupts the homogeneity of space and “reveals the fixed point, the central axis for all future orientation.”⁵

Historical existence and the messianic promise

No matter if Eliade is right in claiming an archetypal validity for the *axis mundi* principle, the Bible provides us with an image that seemingly confirms the idea: **the tree of life planted in the midst of the Garden of Eden, the original habitat of mankind**. From this centre spring the four paradisiacal rivers, the horizontal axes pointing in the four wind directions and delineating the main regions of the world.⁶ **However, Genesis also mentions another tree, the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, similarly located in the centre of Eden**. While the first tree signifies the cosmic axis, providing life and orientation, the second tree is part of the narrative of disobedience and expulsion. It symbolizes man’s grab for divine wisdom, resulting in the loss of innocence, orientation, and natural knowledge. Thus the first three chapters of the Book of Genesis do not primarily provide a narrative about the creation of the cosmos and man’s integration in the regenerative cycles of life, but rather a narrative of alienation from cosmic order and the horrifying awakening in a cursed, hostile, laborious, and ultimately deadly existence. This existence is no longer cosmic; agriculture, the sedentary life integrated in the cosmic cycles, was rejected by God in the sacrifice of Cain.⁷ After the deluge, the patriarchs resumed the existence of Abel, the nomadic life of shepherds. Orientation was no longer provided by cosmic axes, but by a historical axis. This axis was established through a divine promise and connected the existence of the patriarchs with the future return to sedentary life in the Promised Land:

Now the Lord had said unto Abram, Get thee out of thy country, and from thy kindred, and from thy Father' house, unto a land that I will shew thee: And I will make of thee a great nation, and I will bless thee, and make thy name great; and thou shalt be a blessing.⁸

The constitution of the people of God came into existence under the same signs. The patriarchal era was essentially the history of a household, but the covenant at Mount Sinai meant the constitution of the political in historical existence. The symbolical dramas of

⁵ *Ibid.* p. 21.

⁶ Genesis 2:9-14.

⁷ Genesis 4:1-5.

⁸ Genesis 12:1-2.

exodus and covenant articulate Israel's existence in history and the departure from the cosmological order of Egypt. The wandering people of God is the political alternative to the cosmological empires as the dominant symbolic form of society in the ancient Middle East.⁹

Yet, when Israel had settled in the Promised Land, the symbolical form of historical existence no longer seemed to carry weight. The Israelites now wished to abandon their political exceptionalism. While they had wandered about in the desert, a leadership of temporary, charismatic leaders had seemed to conform best to Yahweh's theocratic rule and guidance, symbolically present in the Ark of the Covenant. But now Israel desired to become like other peoples, i.e. to adopt sacred kingship as the political form of the cosmological empires.¹⁰ After a moment of indignation, God made this concession – however, not without a clear warning of the disadvantages of monarchic rule.¹¹ After the failure of Saul, God established the House of David in a new covenant, which included an eternity clause.¹² The journey of Israel seemed to be over. At this point Israel could have permanently merged with the royal world of the Middle East, had not the Yahwist prophets kept the memory of exceptionalism alive. The promise given at Sinai did not say that Israel, after escaping pharaonic slavery, was to become like other peoples. Rather, it said that Israel was chosen as a holy people of priests, as the treasured possession of God.¹³ This included a divinely instituted legal order, which was established immediately after the making of the covenant.

However, in the era of kingship, few rulers were distinguished by just government. Thus the prophets concluded that historical existence had not ended with the establishment of the monarchy. Tyranny, occasionally combined with idolatry, could not be God's final word. Rather the promised, just order lay still in the future, in a messianic kingdom, which was connected with the deficient political reality of the present through the historical axis of the Davidic dynasty.¹⁴ Exactly at this point the symbol of the sacred tree reoccurs, yet in a completely non-cosmological fashion, which bears little resemblance with Eliade's *axis mundi* archetype. In Isaiah 11, the *locus classicus* of messianic prophecy, we read:

⁹ "Israel alone constituted itself by recording its own genesis as a people as an event with a special meaning in history, while the other Eastern societies constituted themselves as analogues of cosmic order. Israel alone had history as an inner form, while the other societies existed in the form of the cosmological myth." Eric Voegelin, *Order and History, vol. 1: Israel and Revelation* (= The Collected Works of Eric Voegelin, vol. 14) (Columbia, MO: University of Missouri Press, 2009), p. 165.

¹⁰ 1 Samuel 8:5.

¹¹ 1 Samuel 8:11-18.

¹² 2 Samuel 7:12.

¹³ Exodus 19:6.

¹⁴ Cf. Gerhard von Rad, *Theologie des Alten Testaments Band 2: Die Theologie der prophetischen Überlieferungen Israels*, 10th ed. (Gütersloh: Kaiser, 1993), p. 176.

And there shall come forth a rod out of the stem of Jesse, and a Branch shall grow out of his roots:

And the spirit of the Lord shall rest upon him, the spirit of wisdom and understanding, the spirit of counsel and might, the spirit of knowledge and of the fear of the Lord;

And shall make him of quick understanding in the fear of the Lord: and he shall not judge after the sight of his eyes, neither reprove after the hearing of his ears:

But with righteousness shall he judge the poor, and reprove with equity for the meek of the earth: and he shall smite the earth with the rod of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips shall he slay the wicked.

And righteousness shall be the girdle of his loins, and faithfulness the girdle of his reins.¹⁵

The Tree of Jesse

In the time of Joachim of Fiore, the second half of the 12th century, the messianic prophecy of Isaiah had become subject to exuberant artistic interpretations in manuscript illuminations, sculptures, frescoes, and stained glass.¹⁶ In fact, the Cistercian Order, to which Joachim initially belonged, played an important role in the dissemination of the Jesse motif.¹⁷ Emile Mâle claims that only Isaiah's prophecy "inspired art in any lasting fashion".¹⁸ The popularity of Isaiah's prophecy in Christian art may be partly explained by the fact that it could be easily combined with the initial sentences of the New Testament, the genealogy of Jesus of Nazareth.¹⁹ In combination, both passages emphasized that Christ is not just a descendent of Abraham, and therefore a member of the elect people; but he is also a descendent of David, and thus the legitimate ruler over the people of God.

The Jesse window of the Cathedral of Chartres (ca. 1140-1150), though no longer considered the oldest representation, provides one of the most magnificent and best preserved versions of the motif. From the reclining Jesse springs a tree, establishing the line of Judean kings and culminating in Christ. Next to the Judean kings we find the prophets of Israel, pointing

¹⁵ Isaiah 11:1-5.

¹⁶ James R. Johnson, "The Tree of Jesse Window of Chartres: *Laudes Regiae*," in *Speculum* 36, 1 (1961), pp. 1-22, at p. 3.

¹⁷ C. R. Dodwell, *The Pictorial Arts of the West 800-1200* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1993), pp. 214-216.

¹⁸ Emile Mâle, *The Gothic Image: Religious Art in France of the Thirteenth Century* (New York: Harper, 1958), p. 165.

¹⁹ Matthew 1:1-17.

upward to Christ. Christ himself is surrounded by the seven spirits, indicating that he fulfills the messianic prophecy of Isaiah.²⁰

Clearly, the tree of Jesse implies some residual elements of fertility and regeneration of the ancient sacred tree imagery, yet the significance is historical, not cosmological. In the High Middle Ages, where the large majority of the believers were analphabets, the image could perfectly illustrate the continuity of the Old and the New Testament and the fulfillment of the Jewish prophecies in Christ. Moreover, the tree of Jesse was traditionally connected to Mariological traditions;²¹ against the Cathar's heretical rejection of the Savior's humanity, by emphasizing Mary's and Christ's human ancestry.²²

More important in this context is the political significance of the motif. As James R. Johnson has shown in his study of the Chartres window, the popularity of the trees of Jesse in the 12th and 13th century must be seen in the context of the medieval conceptions of sacred kingship—in the case of Chartres, the self-interpretation of the Capetian dynasty:

The revival of the Biblical kingship of David, along with the Old Testament rite of royal unctions, reinforced the Frankish image of its nation as the new people chosen by God to execute the plans of Divine Providence, the "new sacred people of promise," as they were styled by the Holy See. Israel, not Rome, was the sacred prototype, with Frankish armies associated not with the legions of Caesar but cast in the role of the columns of Israel fighting with Old Testament heroes like David and Gideon. The Frankish kingship had as its ideal a ruler type modeled upon David, the *Regnum Davidicum*, coupled with that pervasive mediaeval theocratic image of the priestly king, *rex et sacerdos*. The king, through his consecration with holy oil, was like David the Anointed of God, the *christus Domini*, as well as the image of Christ on earth.²³

Thus, the tree of Jesse at Chartres, which incorporates the *fleur-de-lys* as the heraldic emblem of Capetians, alludes to the continuous line of sacred kingship, from the Judean kings through Christ to the contemporary monarchs of France. At the same time it suggests a continuity of

²⁰ Arthur Watson emphasized against Emile Mâle that the abbot Suger was not inventor of the tree of Jesse motif. Arthur Watson, *Early Iconography of the Tree of Jesse* (London: Oxford University Press, 1934). However, as Erwin Panofsky pointed out, the pre-Sugerian trees of Jesse do not yet combine the tree with royal genealogy in the manner of the Chartres and St.-Denis windows and most later depictions. *Abbot Suger on the Abbey Church of St.-Denis and Its Art Treasures*, edited, translated, and annotated by Erwin Panofsky, 2nd ed., (Princeton: Princeton University Press), p. 210.

²¹ Margot Fassler, "Mary's Nativity, Fulbert of Chartres, and the *Stirps Jesse*: Liturgical Innovation circa 1000 and Its Afterlife," in *Speculum* 75, 2 (2000), pp. 389-434.

²² Dodwell, *The Pictorial Arts of the West 800-1200*, p. 214.

²³ Johnson, "The Tree of Jesse Window of Chartres," p. 5.

the elect peoples, from Israel to the Christian church and, more particularly, the Franks. Other examples of the tree of Jesse show that the Capertians were by no means the only royal dynasty that used the motif for the purposes of legitimation.²⁴ I will return to the political significance of the trees of Jesse shortly; but first another biblical tree image deserves consideration.

The tree of election in the Letter to the Romans

In Romans 11, the apostle Paul presents himself as somewhat irritated by the fact that the original elect people, the Jews, did not accept the Gospel and he had to preach to the Gentiles instead. Yet, as he continues, the Jews remain the original people of God, and will ultimately join the community of the elect. The gentiles, therefore, have no reason to claim a privileged position in the economy of God's election. The "return of the Jews," often imagined as mass conversion at the end of times, later became a recurrent topos in apocalyptic literature, also found in the works of Joachim of Fiore.²⁵

For explaining his vision of sacred history Paul refers to the image of the olive tree:

For if the first fruit be holy, the lump is also holy: and if the root be holy, so are the branches.

And if some of the branches be broken off, and thou being a wild olive tree, wert grafted in among them, and with them partakest of the root and fatness of the olive tree;

Boast not against the branches. But if thou boast, thou bearest not the root, but the root thee. [...]

And they also, if they abide not still in unbelief, shall be grafted in: for God is able to graff them in again.

For if thou wert cut out of the olive tree which is wild by nature, and wert grafted contrary to nature into a good olive tree: how much more shall these, which be the natural branches, be grafted into their own olive tree?

²⁴ J. A. Hayes Williams points to an early Bohemian example in the Vysehrad Codex. Jean Anne Hayes Williams, "The Earliest Dated Tree of Jesse Image: Thematically Reconsidered," in *Athanor* 18 (2000), pp. 17-23.

²⁵ For instance *Tractatus super IV evangelia*, ed. Francesco Santi (Roma: Istituto storico italiano per il medio evo, 2002), p. 308.

In other words, Paul compares the economy of divine election to oleiculture. God's operation in history, and especially the election of his people, is like grafting. He is taking care of a harmonious growth of the elect people, by cutting off branches and grafting new ones onto the trunk. The term "history" may seem somewhat misleading when applied to the theology of Paul, as the apostle expected the eschatological events, including the conversion of Jews, to occur within only a short time. By the 12th century, however, the Gentiles were still dominant in the church; and this church looked back at a history that had lasted longer than the history of Israel from David to Christ. Moreover, the conversion of the Jews had still not happened. From this perspective, the tree of election required a profound reconceptualization.

The tree of election and the concordance of the testaments

One can safely claim that the tree is the central symbol in Joachim of Fiore's representation of the course of the people of God. Clear evidence for this claim comes from the famous *Liber Figurarum*, the book of figures, which contains a large number of symbolical drawings;²⁶ most of them depicting trees.

Joachim's early writings must be seen in the context of 12th century apocalyptic speculation, which had reached an unprecedented level of sophistication. In the background was the conflict between the popes and the Hohenstaufen emperors concerning the true representation of Christ on earth. In continuation of the investiture controversy, the violent struggle had cast into doubt the older interpretations of the Christian church as a *corpus mysticum*, jointly governed by the sacerdotal office of the clergy and the royal office of the kings. Now the papacy increasingly claimed sole supremacy over the Christian people and considered the kings as either supporters or enemies of the church. In this situation, many biblical commentators turned to the Revelation of John and read contemporary conflicts through the lens of apocalyptic war scenes.²⁷ The only problem was to find a method that would allow for an exact determination of one's own standpoint in the narrative of the Apocalypse. This would enable the reader to prophesy the outcome of the present conflicts.

²⁶ *Liber Figurarum. Il libro delle Figure dell'abate Gioacchino da Fiore*, ed. Leone Tondelli, Majorie Reeves, and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich (Torino: Società editrice internazionale, 1953). The *Liber Figurarum* was compiled only in the 20th century but the templates of most of the drawings were probably created by Joachim himself. The three major collections of manuscripts, on which it is based and which are found in Reggio Emilia, Oxford, and Dresden, may have been compiled by Joachim's early followers.

²⁷ Cf. Wilhelm Kamlah, *Apokalypse und Geschichtstheologie. Die mittelalterliche Auslegung der Apokalypse vor Joachim von Fiore* (Berlin, 1935).

Joachim of Fiore became famous because many people, including several popes, believed that he had found the solution. How did this happen? This takes us back to the vision of the tree, recounted in the beginning of this essay. The visionary knowledge gained in this vision can be summarized in one sentence: The history of the elect people is structured like a tree and, therefore, the process of salvation and election resembles the growth process of a tree.

At some point Joachim began to draw images of the tree that had appeared to him. Then he added details, limbs and branches, signifying certain elements of salvation history. Then he began to write small explanatory texts on the side of the tree figure he had drawn, interspersed by numerous references to the bible. He would later proceed with other visions in the same way.²⁸ He first expressed his imaginative understanding in the form of drawn figures, before he composed texts which interpreted his vision in more detail. By adding reference after reference, he emphasized that his understanding was not so much a new revelation, but rather a new spiritual insight (*intelligentia spiritualis*) into the biblical revelations about the course of the people of God. The first text of this kind, is the so-called *Genealogia*, an early masterpiece of Joachim, which appears like a template for Joachim's later commentaries on the scriptures. However, the *Genealogy* presents the basic principle of Joachim's historical understanding with a precision rarely found in his later writings. This principle is essentially an expansion on Paul's representation of divine election as oleiculture: the branch of the Gentiles is grafted into the tree of Israel, the original people of God. Yet, Joachim's historical perspective is necessarily a different one than Paul's. While the apostle expected the return of the Jews and the consummation of the election process within a short time, Joachim could already look back at 1200 years of Christian history. Consequently, the Gentiles were not just a branch grafted onto the tree of election; they were a whole new tree grafted onto the first tree of Israel.²⁹ The first section of the *Genealogia* masterfully combines the biblical trees, Isaiah's tree of Jesse and Paul's tree of election, and reevaluates their significance from a 12th century perspective:³⁰

²⁸ For a detailed analysis of Joachim's epistemology see Riedl, *Joachim von Fiore. Denker der vollendeten Menschheit* (Würzburg: Königshausen & Neumann, 2004), pp. 205-220. According to a later tradition, Joachim first painted representations of his inner visions onto the walls of his cloister cell. Reeves, Marjorie and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *The Figurae of Joachim of Fiore* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1972), p. 21.

²⁹ I'd like to advise the reader to look at Tavola II of the *Liber Figurarum*, a figure which resembles most closely the tree described in the *Genealogia*. The figures of the *Liber Figurarum* are easy to find on the internet and, therefore, need not to be reproduced here. A selection of the figures with Italian translations of the inscriptions and short English explanations is found on the website of the Centro di Studi Gioachimiti: http://www.centrostudigioachimiti.it/Gioacchino/GF_tavoleeng.asp. For the tree figure of Tavola II see: http://www.centrostudigioachimiti.it/Gioacchino/tavolaAlberodueAvventi_eng.asp; both websites last accessed on 24 June 2013.

³⁰ My translation follows the critical edition of the text in Gian Luca Potestà, "Die Genealogia. Ein frühes Werk Joachims von Fiore und die Anfänge seines Geschichtsbildes," in *Deutsches Archiv für die Erforschung*

The genealogy of the holy Fathers is to be woven from Adam up to Jacob and is called the trunk of the tree. With Jacob the tree begins to grow the branches of the twelve tribes [of Israel], up to the time of the king Uzziah. [...]. This [first] tree equals the fig tree that was cursed by the Lord because it did not bear fruits.³¹ Yet, just as this fig tree had a beginning (*initium*), a growth (*profectus*) and a decline (*defectus*), the second tree, the grapevine of the New Testament, that is the Church, had a beginning, growth and decline. The beginning of this wine tree was grafted onto the fig tree, because the Church took her departure from the Synagogue. That is why the trunk [of the New Testament] began in the time of King Uzziah, when Isaiah preached more like an Evangelist than a prophet. From there, where the Gospel was preached for the first time, the New Testaments took its beginning. There was a certain middle, where the Synagogue declined and the Church began. From the time of Christ onwards, these second tree, which was grafted [onto the first], grew so many branches, like beginnings (*principia*), meaning the twelve churches. These churches displayed growth and increase (*profectus et augmentum*) up to the time of the Arian barbarians, who destroyed nearly all churches in Africa, the Orient, and Greece, where everyone, who does not keep to the Roman faith, is counted as a heretic [...]. To put it brief, on the old trunk only the tribe Judah remained, from which Christ was born. On the second tree only the Roman Church lasted, which believes without heresy and worships Christ.

As emerging from the quote above, Joachim's basic idea is that the tree of election is made of two trees with exactly the same structure. In other words, the Church, as the new people of God, repeats the history of Israel. Joachim later called his basic hermeneutic idea the principle of *concordia*. This principle implied not only that the church had to go through the same historical epochs, but postulated that every event, every person, and every collective entity of the Old Testament must have its parallel in the New Testament.³²

By "New Testament" Joachim meant the whole history of the church up to Judgment Day. Such an understanding was possible because, as mentioned earlier, many exegetes in the time of Joachim thought that the Revelation of John would be comprised of the entire history of the Church. Joachim had discovered the solution to the enigma of the apocalypse; the key to the Revelation of John was the Old Testament. If he could only find what disasters in the history

des Mittelalters 56/1 (2000), pp. 55-101, at pp. 91-96. For a complete translation of the text and a more detailed commentary see Riedl, *Joachim von Fiore*, pp. 123-150.

³¹ Cf. Matthew 21:18-22.

³² Joachim of Fiore, *Liber Concordiae*, ed. Daniel, p. 62

of Israel refer to the seven seals of the apocalypse; then a basic structure of sacred history would be at hand and, consequently, he could better understand the significance of the parallel disasters that happened to the church, and even the ones that happened in the present and the future.

In the *Liber Concordiae Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, in the same section that speaks about his tree-vision, Joachim explains the precise method of his exegesis as follows: “We first have to put the said trees before our inner eyes (*ponamus suprascriptas arbores ante oculos mentis*) [...]” In these two trees we can recognize the Father and the Son, whereby the Son proceeds from the Father. From another perspective, Joachim says, we recognize in the trees the history of humankind. “The first of these cedar trees signifies the old people, displaying a peculiar resemblance with the Father, while the second one signifies the new people, in the image of the Son.”³³ In other words, the emergence of the Church from Israel, by participation in grace (*gratiae participatio*), relates to the procession of the Son from the Father, who reveal themselves in the Old and New Testament respectively. Therefore, the human mind may not simply invent (*fingere*) parallels between the history of Israel and the Church, but carefully infer them from the text of the scriptures. The contemplation of mental images must be accompanied by meticulous research of biblical narrative.

In this way, Joachim arrives at a sequence of persecutions (*persecutiones*) of Israel, which constitute the seven seals (*sigilla*) of the apocalypse, and a parallel sequence of persecutions of the Church, referring to openings (*apertiones*) of the seals by Christ.³⁴

I quote again from the Genealogia:

In the Old Testament, the first fight was with the Egyptians; the second with the Cananeans; the third with Syrians, the fourth with the Assyrians; the fifth with the Chaldeans; the sixth fight was the one the Medes fought against the Babylonians and then against the children of Israel; the seventh was the fight with the Greeks, when Antiochus expelled [the Jews from] Jerusalem. These seven tribulations were the seven seals, that is, the hidden seals of the things to come. Because nobody knew how to open them until Christ came.

These wars were fought against the children of Israel. In a similar way, the Jews waged a war against the church when the first seal was opened; the second war was the persecution by the pagans; the Syrians can be compared to the Persians,

³³ *Liber Concordiae*, p. 145f., with reference to Ezekiel 17:22f.

³⁴ Revelation 6:1-8:4.

Goths, Vandals, and Lombards, who attacked the church; at the fourth seal, the Saracens rose up against the church; at the fifth seal the new Chaldeans and the new Babylon rose up against the spiritual Jerusalem; at the sixth seal happens the destruction of Babylon, that is Rome. As I said above, seven tribulations happened [in the Old Testament], but the last two are to be understood as one. The tribulation of Antiochus can be compared to the one that will be done by the Antichrist.³⁵

This quotation reveals what is at stake. Joachim is not simply a withdrawn exegete; rather his reading of the Apocalypse is his contribution to the understanding of the contemporary political conflicts, especially the clash between the papacy and the “new Babylon” under the “new Chaldeans”, meaning the Holy Roman Empire under the Hohenstaufen dynasty. The text was written in 1176, when the conflict between Frederick Barbarossa and Pope Alexander III had reached a climax and the emperor’s troops were standing in Italy. In this struggle, Joachim acted clearly as a partisan of the popes and the Roman clergy – despite his later reputation as the prophet of clerical decline. In the *Genealogia*, he announces the destruction of Babylon, i.e. the empire, as a biblical truth. However, the abbot’s service to the popes goes far beyond this and explains why he was quite popular with the Roman Curia.

On the one hand, he defends the claims of Rome against the Eastern Churches: only Rome is orthodox, and therefore only Rome will last. The heretical churches were partly erased by the forces of Islam already and the rest will undergo the same fate, unless they submit to Rome; just as in Israel only the tribe of Juda (and its true companion Benjamin) remained, while the other tribes were annihilated. On the other hand, Joachim helps the popes to find their role in their fight with the emperors. What matters most is the parallel between the Kings of Israel, the rulers of the Old people of God, and the popes, as the rulers of the New People of God. Evidently, Joachim was inspired by the logic of the Trees of Jesse, but instead of giving legitimacy to a royal dynasty, he used the image for affirming the universal spiritual leadership of the papacy.

Unfortunately, we cannot go into the many interesting details here, which allow Joachim to identify certain popes with certain Judean kings. The main message is clear: the popes are the legitimate rulers of the elect people of God, and the German rulers have to obey. The popes are the spiritual descendants of Christ and, because Christ is a descendant of David, the popes are also the successors of the Kings of Israel. This is a highly political message in a time

³⁵ Joachim of Fiore, *Genealogia*, ppf. Unless indicated otherwise, all translations from Joachim are my own.

where the basic controversy between popes and emperors centres on the question of who is the true Vicar of Christ on earth.³⁶

To sum up at this point: In his early writings, the image of the tree helped Joachim to understand the course of divine election. The historical formation of the people of God is presented as an organic processes of growth (*profectus*), where strong elements flourish, weak elements decay and fall off, and new elements sprout. The force behind these processes is divine election, which—as the inspired exegete of the Apocalypse recognizes—proceeds according to a preconceived plan of structural repetition. While the Old Testament told the story of Israel’s election and the survival of the pious tribe Juda, the New Testament revealed the election of the Gentiles and the ultimate survival of the Roman Church. This understanding of the process of election finally allows Joachim to gain prophetic insight into his own historical situation: The sixth seal was about to be opened, bringing about the destruction of the church’s fiercest enemy, the empire, prefigured in the decline of Babylon. Or, more concretely, Pope Alexander III will prevail over Emperor Frederick I.

Yet, the prophetic insight goes beyond the present moment, wherefore the *Genealogia* may not merely be understood as a piece of curial propaganda. In the last section of world history the Roman Church would stand alone against the last enemy of God’s elect people, the Antichrist himself. The Antichrist is prefigured in the Diadochi ruler Antiochus IV Epiphanes, according to the Book of Daniel the worst and final tyrant of the worst and final empire to rule over Israel.³⁷ At least at this point, it is important for Joachim to stress that it will be a pope who will lead the people of God into the final battle. There are reasons to believe that Joachim’s apocalyptic narrative was meant as a counter-narrative to the prevailing imperial apocalypses – e.g. the famous *Ludus de Antichristo* – where a Last Emperor is the ultimate leader of the elect.³⁸

Nevertheless, if this would have been Joachim’s final word, he would have been largely forgotten today – maybe remembered by some specialized medievalists as a curious example of an apocalyptic exegete. But this is not the end of the story.

³⁶ Walter Ullmann, *The Growth of Papal Government in the Middle Ages. A Study in the Ideological Relation of Clerical to Lay Power* (London: Methuen, 1970), p. 264; cf. Richard W. Southern, *Western Society and the Church in the Middle Ages* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1970), pp. 15-34.

³⁷ Cf. Daniel 2:40-43, 7:7f., 7:23-25.

³⁸ See my evaluation of Joachim’s work *De prophetia ignota* in Riedl, *Joachim von Fiore*, 2004, pp. 150-168.

The Third Age

The reason why we still remember Joachim of Fiore today is another highly influential discovery which, however, builds on his earlier insight in the concordance of the testaments. In the *Genealogia*, Joachim had paralleled the Jewish synagogue with the Christian church. In his later writings, he complemented the historical dimension with a social one. The synagogue begins with Noah and Abraham, with the great patriarchs and, therefore, has a patriarchal structure. This is no surprise because the order of the old people of God is based solely on the revelation of the Father, the Old Testament.³⁹

The principal idea is that the elect people will always assume a particular social form, conforming to the available knowledge of God. When Christ revealed himself, the social structure and the government of the people of God changed. Christ had no carnal children, rather he procreated by preaching and through the sacrament. Accordingly, popes and priests are not the biological offspring of Christ, but His spiritual children. This principle of making children by the sacrament of ordination yields the clergy.⁴⁰

However, there were two major problems with this scheme. The theological problem was that the Christian God is not two persons, but three. In Joachim's early writings the Holy Spirit was not seen as constituting his own stage of revelation, since the Bible evidently consisted of only two testaments. The social problem was that Joachim's own estate, the monks, were not represented in his scheme. As we have seen, Joachim supported the popes; but he was also highly critical of the clergy of his time. He had joined the reform-oriented Cistercian order, until he founded his own even stricter congregation, the Florentians.⁴¹ In his time the Hierarchies of Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite had gained a lot of popularity in the higher clergy, as the books paralleled the nine orders of the clergy with the nine choirs of the angelic heaven. Consequently, the higher clergy hoped to obtain higher ranks also in the heavenly order. Joachim struggled with these ideas, as shown in his *Palterium Decem Chordarum* and his *Tractatus super IV evangelia* in particular.⁴²

In one of his own visions Joachim had recognized that the heavenly hierarchy was shaped like the triangular Psalter.⁴³ The ten-stringed musical instrument represented the nine angelic

³⁹ Joachim von Fiore, *Liber Concordiae*, ed. Daniel pp. 256-258.

⁴⁰ Joachim von Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim* (Venice, 1527; reprint Frankfurt am Main: Minerva, 1964), fol. 18vb.

⁴¹ Cf. Stephen E. Wessley, *Joachim of Fiore and Monastic Reform* (New York: Peter Lang, 1990).

⁴² A direct reference to Pseudo-Dionysius is found in Joachim of Fiore, *Tractatus super IV evangelia*, ed. Santi, p. 300.

⁴³ Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium decem chordarum* ed. Kurt-Victor Selge, MGH, Quellen zur Geistesgeschichte des Mittelalters 20 (Hannover, 2009), p. 10.

choirs, augmented by restored mankind as the tenth and highest string. However, Joachim was unwilling to accept that the clerics, especially the largely corrupt secular clergy, would take the highest ranks in God's celestial court. What about the monks? Did they not praise the Lord with more devotion and effort than the priests with all their worldly responsibilities? Moreover, did not the recent explosion of monastic varieties –Cistercians, Carthusians, Premonstratensians, Knights Hospitaller, Knights Templar, and many more – prove that the whole church and all three estates tended toward monastic forms of existence?

The solution to all these problems was Joachim's vision on Easter 1184, which he vividly describes in the introduction to his *Exposition in Apocalypsim*.⁴⁴ He received the final confirmation of an idea he had conceived already in earlier writings and which provided the answers to all his questions: The revelation of the Son was not the conclusion of the process of revelation; rather the Holy Spirit would initiate his own period, a third age (*tertius status*) of sacred history. This would not mean a Third Testament, but a higher spiritual understanding (*intellectus spiritualis*) of the Old and New Testaments. With the Easter experience and its manifold implications all parts of Joachim's exegetic and contemplative intuitions seemed to fall into place. All spheres of existence seemed to be interconnected, from deity to society.

As a contemplative theologian, Joachim came to understand the meaning of the Western creed: The three persons are co-equal and co-eternal, the only difference between them lies in their relations, in the way they proceed from each other. The Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son, the Son only from the Father, while the Father does not proceed from another person but is the origin of all processions. Joachim's innovation lies primarily in connecting these eternal and transcendent processions (*processiones*) with the manifestations of the divine persons in human history, the divine missions (*missiones*).⁴⁵ The Father is not sent into the world, as he also does not proceed from another person; but he sends his Son. Finally, however, Father and Son send the Holy Spirit into the world, to initiate the third age.

As an exegete Joachim understands the meaning of processions and missions for the human comprehension (*intellectus*) of divine revelation. Before the sending of the Son, humans know only the letter of the Old Testament, but with the incarnation they learn how Christ is the fulfilment of the Old Testament, how the letter of the New Testament proceeds from Old Testament. Yet, this is not the end of human understanding, as the mission of the Spirit—

⁴⁴ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, fol. 39va.

⁴⁵ Riedl, *Joachim von Fiore*, pp. 221-225.

Joachim imagines it like a future universal Pentecost—will bring a spiritual understanding of the testaments beyond the mere letter.⁴⁶

As a social theorist Joachim supposes that the people of God always assume a social order conforming to the available knowledge of God. Accordingly, the clerical church, emulating the Son, emerges from the patriarchal synagogue which emulates the Father. However, Joachim's new insight allows him to formulate a new progressive paradigm of social change. The revelation of the Spirit will result in a reorganization of the people of God according to spiritual principles. Christianity will become a spiritual and monastic church, emerging from the synagogue, where it has been prefigured by monastic prophets such as Elisha and Elijah, as well as from the clerical church, where it was anticipated in the coenobitic life of the Benedictine monks. The spiritual church (*ecclesia spiritualis*) will comprise all three estates, mirroring the Trinity; but it will be governed by monks.⁴⁷ Since the spiritual church is the final form of the people of God, it perfectly prefigures the social order of the Heavenly Jerusalem.⁴⁸ Consequently, the monks will take the highest ranks in the final order of the church as well as in the beyond.

The progressivist reshaping of the tree of election

In one of his shorter commentaries on the Apocalypse, the *Praepatio super Apocalypsim*, Joachim summarized the essential idea of his new triadic and progressivist scheme of history: Man was originally created in the image and likeness of God, as the Book of Genesis says,⁴⁹ but with Adam's fall the likeness was lost and, therefore, also man's knowledge about God. God then began a long process of re-education at the end of which mankind would reassume the likeness of God—this time in the threefold social structure of the spiritual church.

Thus it is proper for mankind after the guilt of the first man to return gradually (*gradatim*) to the cognition of its creator; so it may be rooted (*radicare*) in the first

⁴⁶ Cf. Herbert Grundmann, 'Lex und Sacramentum bei Joachim von Fiore', in *Ausgewählte Aufsätze Teil 2: Joachim von Fiore*, Schriften der MGH, 25, 2 (Stuttgart: Hiersemann, 1977), pp. 403-420.

⁴⁷ For a detailed analysis of Joachim's constitutional ideas see Matthias Riedl, "A Collective Messiah – Joachim of Fiore's Constitution of Future Society," in *Mirabilia* 14 (2012), pp. 57-80.

⁴⁸ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, fol. 221rb.

⁴⁹ Genesis 1:27.

time of the Father, sprout (*germinare*) in the second time of the Son and experience the sweet fruit (*fructus experiri dulcedinem*) in the third age of the Holy Spirit.⁵⁰

Evidently, Joachim is taking recourse to botanic symbolism for expressing his basic scheme and, thereby, refers us back to the tree image. Yet, in Joachim's later representations the tree of election has changed its shape. One of the figures in the *Liber Figurarum* simply augments the older tree figure by a top section signifying the third age.⁵¹ This, however, does not really capture the full significance of Joachim's innovative thinking about the process of election and the course of the people of God. In Joachim's mature works, the growth of the people of God is no longer just a matter of quantitative growth; it has now become a matter of qualitative growth.

The word *profectus*, the Latin word for growth which translates the Greek *prokope*, is filled with new meaning. In the *Genealogia* it addressed the growth of the church out of the synagogue, which transformed a national conception of the elect people into a universal one. Now it signifies the gradual perfection of the people of God through a sequence of transformations. In other words, Joachim discovered the principle of social progress. Such a double meaning of *prokope/profectus* is already implied in the Greek and Vulgate versions of Paul's Letter to the Philippians. There, the concept, on the one hand, expresses the spreading of the Gospel,⁵² and, on the other hand, the community's progress in faith.⁵³ And even today, we often use the concepts of growth and progress synonymously, especially in the economic sphere. In Joachim, however, the botanic symbolism expresses his understanding of social progress as an organic progress, guided by God's gradual revealing of himself. This needs to be emphasized, since Joachim's later followers among the Franciscan Spirituals and other more radical movements abandoned the organic scheme and replaced it with a sequence of revolutionary breaks.

Joachim also undoubtedly expected tremendous tribulations in which the church would be tested. However, he was not a revolutionary thinker, but a theorist of gradual and organic reform. Naturally, his ideas had their origin not only in the vision of trees but were strongly informed by contemporary developments. On the one hand, the abbot stood in the tradition of the Gregorian reform movement and the papal policy since the investiture controversy; the

⁵⁰ Joachim of Fiore, *Praephatio super Apocalypsim*, ed. Kurt-Victor Selge, 'Eine Einführung Joachims von Fiore in die Johannesapokalypse', in *Deutsches Archiv für die Erforschung des Mittelalters* 46/1 (1990), pp. 85-131, at 102.

⁵¹ *Liber Figurarum*, tav. I.

⁵² Philippians 1:12.

⁵³ Philippians 1:25.

liberty of the church (*libertas ecclesiae*) was to be accomplished by depriving the secular rulers of all control. On the other hand, Joachim observed the Cistercian movement as well as the manifold forms of monasticism which spread, with yet unknown speed, across the West. Therefore, Joachim went beyond the goals of the Gregorian reformers in two respects. Firstly, in his eyes the purification of the clergy was not sufficient; the church had to become a monastic and spiritual church. Secondly, it was not enough to liberate the church from the hands of lay rulers; the liberty of the church was only complete once the secular powers no longer existed. Such a pure church, Joachim knew, would conquer the world—not by crusades, but rather by its absolutely convincing appearance.⁵⁴ The Greek Christians would give up their heresies and submit to Rome, the Gentiles would adopt the Gospel, and the Jews would collectively return to the elect people.⁵⁵

All these ideas played a role in Joachim's reshaping of the tree of election. The most magnificent drawing contained in the *Liber Figurarum* sums up what Joachim ultimately understood as *profectus*, the growth and progress of mankind.⁵⁶ At the bottom of the trunk we see this time not Jesse but the patriarch Noah, the elect survivor of the deluge. Noah had three sons, who were to become the ancestors of three humankinds. Joachim's tree image represents them as three branches sprouting from the root of Noah.⁵⁷ One of the sons is an evil character, Ham; his branch dies off before it can flourish. The other two branches constitute the tree of election, which is shaped like three consecutive circles, signifying the three ages. In the first age of the Father the branch of Shem flourishes; his descendants are called the Semites or the Jews. However, in the second age of the Spirit, their branch deteriorates. Instead the descendants of Japheth, the Gentiles, are flourishing. But in the coming third age of the Spirit, the Jewish branches, which were broken off in the second age, will be grafted back onto the tree of election. Gentiles and Jews will come together in the universal spiritualized people of God. All the elect from all parts of mankind will be part of one tree, just as the Apostle Paul has predicted in the Letter to the Romans.

⁵⁴ E. Randolph Daniel, "Apocalyptic Conversion: The Joachite Alternative to the Crusades," in: *Joachim of Fiore in Christian Thought. Essays on the Influence of the Calabrian Prophet*, ed. Delno West, 2 vols. (New York: Franklin, 1975), vol. 2, pp. 310-328.

⁵⁵ Joachim of Fiore, *Liber Concordiae*, fol. 85rb and fol. 117ra; *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, fol.8va; *Tractatus super IV evangelia*, ed. Santi, p. 237.

⁵⁶ , tav. XXII; the drawing is available at the website of the Centro di Stud Gioachimiti, http://www.centrostudigioachimiti.it/Gioacchino/tavolaAlberoTrinita_eng.asp; last accessed on 24 June 2013.

⁵⁷ *Liber Concordiae*, fol. 73va.

Conclusion: from election to selection

Joachim of Fiore's vision of spiritual progress and social perfection has inspired social movements from the Franciscans in the 13th century to communists in the 19th and 20th century. Of course, this progressivist optimism also has its problematic sides; and some authors have made Joachim responsible for various delusions and disasters in history. However, in this essay I did not discuss the validity of such claims.⁵⁸ Within the context of this volume, the significance of Joachim of Fiore maybe summarized briefly as follows:

In the writings of Joachim of Fiore the concept of the elect people of God undergoes a fundamental change. It now denotes a collective entity which, on the one hand, is the carrier of historical progress and, on the other hand, is subject to internal socio-religious dynamics. The people of God, having the form of the patriarchy in the pre-Christian age of the Father, transforms into the clerical church in the age of the Son and, ultimately, into a monastic church in the future third age of the Holy Spirit. The mighty crown of the tree, as found in the drawing of the *Liber Figurarum*, is the prophetic symbol of the universal people of God which, after the conversion of the Jews and the reform of the Church, will have reached spiritual perfection and mark the end of history. Put differently, God's election is not the result of any achievements; rather election and the subsequent dispensation of revelatory knowledge allows for a progressive social development within the people of God. In the final form, the people of God will have reached the perfection of the Heavenly Jerusalem and, therefore, qualify for an immortal existence in the beyond. This pattern of election, perfection, and redemption established a powerful model for social self-interpretation in modernity.

There is yet another long-term impact of Joachim's organic progressivism. Today we do not believe anymore that our ancestors are Adam, Noah, or Jesse. Today we believe in evolution, in our descent from apes. Yet, why is the popular understanding of the process of evolution one of progress? One may ask whether or not certain categories of Christian historical understanding rather prepared the ground for a comprehensive doctrine of revolution—instead of obstructing it, as is the common perception. The idea of progress itself is not result of biological research but rather a way of interpreting the results of biological research.⁵⁹ The sciences did not play the slightest role in the emergence of progressive thinking; rather the context was the medieval reform of the church. As a theorist of reform Joachim came to

⁵⁸ Cf. Matthias Riedl, "Gioacchino da Fiore padre della modernità. Le tesi di Eric Voegelin," in: *Gioacchino da Fiore nella cultura dell'800 e del '900. Atti del 6° Congresso internazionale di studi gioachimiti*, ed. Gian Luca Potestà (Rome: Viella, 2005), pp. 219-236.

⁵⁹ Karl Löwith, "Das Verhängnis des Fortschritts," in *Die Idee des Fortschritts. Neun Vorträge über Wege und Grenzen des Fortschrittsglaubens*, ed. Erich Burck (Munich: Beck, 1963), pp. 17-40, at p. 18.

understand the creation of mankind as a long historical process;⁶⁰ sacred history was determined by transformations (*mutationes*) of the elect and the extinction of those who refused to change.

The illustrations in Ernst Haeckel's tremendously popular *Natürliche Schöpfungsgeschichte* (*Natural History of Creation*) of 1868 show that the basic symbolism remained the same. Haeckel presented mankind as the crown of the tree of life, as the final result of a long process of variation and selection.⁶¹ The modern tree of life, of course, is no longer a cosmic pole or an *axis mundi*, as described by Mircea Eliade; rather it is an historical axis, no matter if it represents social or natural history. As a result of this popular Darwinism, we humans can no longer consider ourselves as the center of creation; but we may regard ourselves as the result of biological perfection, as the culmination of nature's oleiculture, so to speak. Nature has replaced God, and selection has replaced election, certainly. Nevertheless, our search for orientation and self-understanding still follows the Jewish-Christian logic of historical existence.

⁶⁰ Cf. *Liber Concordiae*, V, 3-23.

⁶¹ Ernst Haeckel, *Natürliche Schöpfungsgeschichte. Gemeinverständliche wissenschaftliche Vorträge über die Entwicklungslehre im Allgemeinen und diejenige von Darwin, Goethe und Lamarck im Besonderen, über die Anwendung derselben auf den Ursprung des Menschen und andere damit zusammenhängende Grundfragen der Naturwissenschaft* (Berlin: Georg Reimer, 1868). See especially lecture 23 on the family tree of man.